

Seven Vows, Zero Preparation

Third in a series on marriage, tradition, and the lives we need to build together

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ABOUT THIS PIECE

An opinion column examining India's paradox: we have preserved the Saptapadi - the seven vows of Hindu marriage - word for word across centuries, yet spent almost no time teaching people what they mean. Drawing on Vedic tradition and the scriptural understanding of grihastha ashrama, the piece calls for temples and family priests to serve as the institution that prepares couples before marriage - unpacking the vows, building shared understanding, and restoring the role of women as spiritual guides that our tradition always intended.



Auto giants' shutdown triggers crisis, 2 lakh workers face uncertainty

PNS : JAMSHEDPUR

A major economic slowdown has gripped the Adityapur Industrial Area (AIA) following the simultaneous block closures announced by Tata Motors and Tata Cummins, severely affecting hundreds of ancillary industries and putting the livelihoods of nearly two lakh workers at risk.

Tata Motors has suspended production at its Jamshedpur plant for seven days from May 29 to June 4, while Tata Cummins has declared a block closure on June 1 and 2, along with flexi-offs on May 30 and June 3. The coordinated shutdown has disrupted the industrial ecosystem of

Adityapur, which is heavily dependent on these two automobile giants.

Nearly 90 percent of the small and medium-scale industries in the industrial area manufacture components such as forgings, castings, machined parts, rims, fasteners, and rubber and fibre products for Tata Motors and Tata Cummins. With orders coming to an abrupt halt, production activities across the industrial belt have been severely impacted.

Industry leaders described the situation as alarming, citing rising production costs and a sudden drop in demand. Large quantities of finished goods are lying idle in warehouses as supply



channels remain frozen. According to the Adityapur Small Scale Industries Association (ASIA), while some units are utilizing the shutdown period to clear pending work, around 10 to 15 percent of small-scale industries have temporarily suspended operations.

The industrial slowdown has also created a significant employment crisis. Around 50,000 workers employed directly in manufacturing units are facing disruptions, while an estimated 1.5 lakh workers associated with transportation, logistics, supply chains, and allied sectors are expected to suffer income losses during the closure period.

Amid the widespread slowdown, the Govindpur-based Steel Strips Wheels Company is reportedly continuing normal operations, providing a rare exception within the industrial landscape.

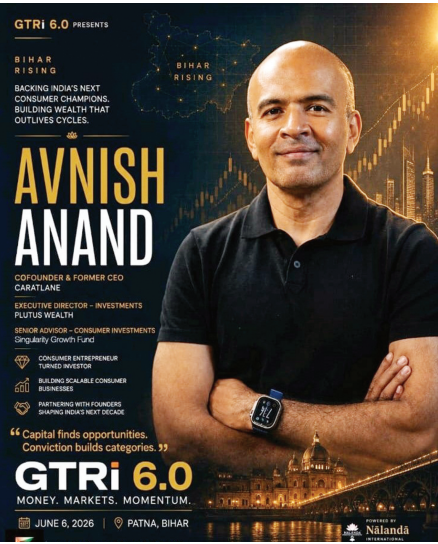
Meanwhile, Tata Cummins Private Limited has issued guidelines for employees during the closure period. As per the company's circular, 50 percent of the leave period during the block closure will be adjusted against employees' leave accounts, while the remaining period will be compensated through normal salary payments. Employees assigned duty on a roster basis have been directed to report to work, failing which they will be

required to avail full personal leave.

The company has also stated that employees called to work on May 30 and June 3 will have to complete compensatory work within the next two months. The shutdown period will continue to be treated as a working period for calculating statutory benefits, including Privilege Leave and Leave Travel Allowance.

Industrial stakeholders have expressed concern that if such production disruptions continue for an extended period, the economic consequences could be severe for both industries and workers dependent on the Adityapur industrial hub.

Bihar's Three Bets: How the State Can Finally Close the Gap



BY AVNISH ANAND

Bihar remains at the bottom of India's development rankings, with the country's lowest per capita income. Even other BIMARU states have moved significantly ahead, with Uttar Pradesh's per capita income now about 1.5 times higher. The widening gap highlights the urgent need for economic growth, which is essential to fund improvements in healthcare, education, and infrastructure.

Despite its potential, Bihar's economy remains largely agrarian. Industrial investment has been limited, ease of doing business remains weak, and the state has missed major growth waves in sectors such as IT, financial services, and advanced manufacturing. To reverse this trend, Bihar needs a practical growth strategy built around its own strengths rather than attempting to replicate states such as Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, or Maharashtra.

What Does an Economic Revival Require?

Economic revival requires three key ingredients: a government committed to growth, a credible strategy based on Bihar's strengths, and private investment supported by business-friendly policies. Recent examples from Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan show that states can achieve rapid progress by focusing on their natural advantages and aligning them with national priorities. Bihar has three major opportunities that could drive such a transformation.

Opportunity 1: Turning Agricultural Abundance into Agribusiness Scale
Bihar possesses fertile land, extensive irrigation, a favourable climate, and river connectivity that can support low-cost transportation. Rising global demand for food presents a major opportunity to transform traditional farming into modern agribusiness.

The state has already made progress through the Fourth Agriculture Roadmap (2023-28), increased focus on horticulture, and promotion of niche products such as makhana. The success of agri-tech startup DeHaat highlights the potential for innovation in the sector.

However, fragmented landholdings remain a major challenge, limiting productivity and mechanisation. Expanding models such as

contract farming, Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs), and cooperatives will be critical to achieving scale. If these issues are addressed, agriculture can become a powerful engine of economic growth.

Opportunity 2: Labour-Driven Industrialisation

Bihar has one of India's largest pools of low-cost labour, much of which migrates to other states for work. Creating local employment opportunities could help retain workers and strengthen the state's economy.

Labour-intensive manufacturing has been a proven development model in countries such as Vietnam, Bangladesh, and Mexico. By attracting industries such as textiles, footwear, and assembly manufacturing, Bihar could create jobs, generate investment, and gradually move up the value chain.

The biggest challenge is investor confidence. Bihar's poor ease-of-doing-business record continues to discourage private investment. The state therefore needs a successful industrial project that demonstrates its ability to support business. Odisha's success in attracting a \$100 million investment from the Epic Group for apparel manufacturing offers a useful example. Bihar needs a similar proof of concept to attract larger investments.

Opportunity 3: Realising Bihar's Underserved Tourism Potential

Bihar is home to some of the world's most important religious and historical sites. As the birthplace of Buddhism and Jainism and home to Nalanda and Vaishali, it possesses tourism assets of global significance.

Yet visitor numbers and tourism revenues remain well below potential due to inadequate infrastructure, connectivity issues, safety concerns, and limited hospitality facilities. Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh provide successful models. Rajasthan built a strong tourism economy around its heritage assets, while Uttar Pradesh transformed destinations such as Ayodhya and Varanasi through large-scale infrastructure investment and promotion. Bihar can follow a similar path by improving tourist infrastructure, enhancing connectivity and safety, encouraging hospitality investment, and marketing its destinations more effectively.

A well-developed tourism sector could attract domestic pilgrims, international Buddhist travellers, and heritage tourists, generating substantial economic activity.

The Ask
Bihar's strengths-fertile land, abundant labour, and globally significant cultural heritage-remain underutilised. To unlock their potential, the state must improve infrastructure, simplify regulations, encourage private investment, and make ease of doing business a competitive advantage.

Most importantly, Bihar needs a visible success story. A well-executed private investment of Rs 500-1,000 crore could demonstrate that business can thrive in the state and encourage others to follow. Such a breakthrough could change investor perceptions and set Bihar on a path toward sustained economic growth.

Avnish Anand is cofounder and former CEO Caratlane

Loan dispute led to murder of Para Teacher in Palamu

PNS : DALTONGANJ

Police have solved the murder of a 50-year-old para teacher within a day of registering the case, arresting another para teacher who allegedly killed him over a loan dispute.

The body of Uday Singh was recovered on the night of May 28 from the junction of the Chhaterpur and Paton roads. His post-mortem examination was conducted at Medinirai Medical College and Hospital (MMCH), Daltonganj, on May 29.

Officer-in-Charge of Chhaterpur Police Station Saurabh Choubey said the deceased had sustained multiple injuries inflicted with a sharp traditional weapon locally known as a pharsa.

Following a complaint lodged by Singh's wife on May 29, police registered an FIR under Section 103 (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Superintendent of Police Kapil Chaudhary directed SDPO Chhaterpur P. Kumar to lead the investigation.

Acting on a combination of technical surveillance and human intelligence inputs, police arrested Surender Yadav (40), a para teacher posted at a government school in Dendi village. During interrogation, Yadav allegedly confessed to the crime and handed over Singh's mobile phone to investigators.

Police said Yadav was neither named nor suspected in the FIR. However, investigators were able to identify him through evidence gathered during the probe.

According to police, the motive behind the murder was a financial dispute. Yadav had allegedly borrowed Rs 25,000 from Singh around six months ago. Singh had been demanding repayment and claimed that the amount had risen to Rs 50,000 with interest.

"A few days before the murder, a heated argument broke out between the two para teachers over the loan. The dispute escalated and allegedly prompted Yadav to plan and execute the killing," Choubey said.

Singh was posted as a para teacher at a government school in Chilho Khurd village, while Yadav worked at another government school in nearby Dendi village, about 1.5 kilometres away. Police said the two were once close friends, but their relationship deteriorated over the loan dispute.

Investigators claim to have gathered strong evidence against the accused, including the recovery of Singh's mobile phone and the murder weapon. The pharsa had been recovered from the crime scene along with the victim's body on the day of the incident.

Police have also seized the motorcycle allegedly used by Yadav during the commission of the crime.

The accused has been sent into judicial custody, and further investigation is underway.

Commercial Tax Dept hosts special awareness drive in Dumka



PNS : DUMKA

In a concerted effort to promote registration, compliance, and awareness regarding the Jharkhand Professional Tax and the Goods and Services Tax (GST), the Commercial Tax Department, Dumka Circle Office, organised a special camp at the Agrasen Bhavan in Dumka. The initiative aimed to bridge the information gap and encourage local businesses to seamlessly integrate into the formal tax ecosystem.

The event was held in the presence of key departmental officials, including State Tax Assistant Commissioner Sanjay Kumar, State Tax Officers Pradeep Kumar Mehra and Bindu Kumari Mehta, along with computer operators Ranjit Kumar and Sumit Kumar. Addressing a substantial gathering of local businessmen and tax

consultants, the officials provided detailed insights into the overarching framework of the state and central tax regimes. They comprehensively explained the step-by-step procedures for Professional Tax and GST registration, the requisite documentation, the process for filing periodic returns, and the long-term benefits of robust tax compliance.

During the session, the departmental authorities made an earnest appeal to all eligible businessmen, commercial establishments, and employers to ensure timely adherence to the essential compliances. They emphasized that proactive tax management not only protects businesses from regulatory hurdles but also ensures they become a vital, contributing part of the state and central government's economic infrastructure. The camp proved highly

interactive, featuring a dedicated session where attending traders and tax consultants raised various queries pertaining to tax registration, return filing, tax payment mechanisms, and other related subjects. The officials proactively addressed these concerns, effectively resolving the issues and clearing misconceptions on the spot.

Concluding the camp, the officials reiterated the department's ongoing commitment to facilitating the trading community. They stated that organizing such awareness camps is instrumental in disseminating vital information regarding tax regulations directly to the stakeholders. By doing so, the department aims to simplify the complexities of taxation, making compliance far more effective, accessible, and trader-friendly.

Over 1.19 Lakh 'Unmapped' voters identified in Pakur

PNS : PAKUR

A total of 119,648 voters in Pakur district have been identified as "unmapped" during the pre-Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise after their records could not be matched with the 2003 electoral rolls, according to election officials.

The unmapped voters

include 54,021 in Pakur Assembly constituency, 36,122 in Maheshpur, and 29,505 in Litipara. Under the Election Commission's SIR programme, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) will conduct a door-to-door verification drive from June 30 to July 29, 2026. Voters classified as unmapped will be required to submit identity documents

to verify their eligibility for inclusion in the electoral roll.

According to the Pakur District Election Office, the district currently has 805,067 registered voters, of whom 730,419 have already been mapped. The district's electorate has grown significantly from 497,889 voters in 2003, reflecting an increase of more than 3.5 lakh voters

over the past 23 years.

Meanwhile, election authorities have approved 54 new polling stations in the district to accommodate the growing voter base. The total number of polling booths will increase from 1,014 to 1,068. Assistant Election Officer Manohar Marandi said Pakur Assembly constituency will get 41 new booths,

Maheshpur six, and Litipara seven. Officials said the expansion aims to ensure that each polling station serves no more than 1,200 voters.

The final status of the unmapped voters will be determined after completion of the SIR exercise and publication of the revised electoral rolls.

SEVEN VOWS, ZERO PREPARATION

Third in a series on marriage, tradition, and the lives we need to build together



BY NIVEDITA PANDEY

We inherited a tradition that measured character over history. We then built a marriage culture that does the opposite. Modern marriage discourse - its obsession with purity, past relationships, and social compliance - reduces this tradition to a black-and-white judgement on our own scriptures never made. Virginity is socially visible. Character is psycho-

logically complex. And it is character - how you treat your partner, how you repair trust, how you navigate difficulty - that determines what life inside a home feels like.

A Catholic friend shared that in her denomination, marriage is a fresh start - whatever came before the threshold stays there. Our tradition said the same thing. Satyakam became a great sage not because of lineage but because of character. Devi Ahilya was redeemed and elevated not because her past was erased, but because it was met with grace rather than permanent verdict. The relevant question before marriage should not be: Has this person had a past?

It should be - What kind of person are they now? Can they be honest? Can they take responsibility? Can they handle conflict without cruelty? Can they respect someone's dignity even when they are hurt? Did they grow from experience, or

repeat harmful patterns?

If our tradition understood character over history, complexity over condemnation, and redemption over lifelong punishment - why have we built no institutions to prepare people for the commitment that is central to life?

The Vedic framework understood grihastha ashrama as the most demanding life stage. The seven vows of the Saptapadi - shared sustenance, shared strength, shared prosperity, progeny, shared harmony, long life, enduring friendship - were a curriculum. They were meant to be understood, and committed to - not recited mindlessly by two people who never discussed what respect looks like inside their home.

At most weddings today, the vows are performed but the meaning is never unpacked. Two people make the most consequential decision of their lives having assessed only astrological and

material compatibility, not emotional, psychological, or relational compatibility. This is the gap that needs filling. The institution best placed to fill it is one millions of Hindu families already trust - their local temples and family priests.

The pandit called to perform your wedding already knows your family, commands your trust, and understands the vows he recites - making him the natural guide for this, well before the ceremony begins. Where the pandit is unavailable, temples could designate trained guides.

The pandit or these guides should sit with the couple before the wedding - not to conduct rituals, but to discuss what the vows mean, what the scriptures say about building a shared life, and what inner qualities our tradition considers essential.

This preparation cannot be delivered only by men. It needs trained female marriage guides as well. The

bride in every wedding receives blessings but not counsel. Trained women guides - learned in the tradition - can hold space for the questions brides rarely get to ask. This model of women as spiritual authority is not new to Bharat.

We have preserved these vows word for word across centuries. We have spent almost no time teaching people what they mean. It is time temples restored both - the curriculum our tradition always intended, and the women who always belonged in that room.

NIVEDITA PANDEY IS AN AI AND DIGITAL INNOVATION LEADER WORKING AT THE INTERSECTION OF TECHNOLOGY, GOVERNANCE, AND SOCIAL IMPACT. RAISED ACROSS BIHAR AND JHARKHAND, SHE IS A WHARTON MBA ALUMNA AND HAS WORKED ACROSS USA, UK, SINGAPORE, AND INDIA. SHE CAN BE REACHED AT NIVEDITAPANDEY@ALUMNI.UPEN.N.EDU

Students shine in SOF International Olympiads 2025-26

PNS : RANCHI

In a remarkable display of academic excellence, students from Ranchi, Bokaro, Jamshedpur have brought laurels to the city with their outstanding performance in the Science Olympiad Foundation (SOF) examinations for the academic year 2025-26. This year's SOF Olympiad witnessed participation from millions of students across 70 countries, including more than 38 thousand students from Ranchi, 23 thousand students from Bokaro, 19 thousand students from Jamshedpur.

Among the top performers from Ranchi, Virat Gupta (Class 4) from Kairali School in the International General Knowledge Olympiad (IGKO), Parinika Purvi (Class 1) from Jawahar Vidya Mandir in the International Mathematics Olympiad (IMO), and Anna Isabel Tirkey (Class 1) from PM Shri Kendriya Vidyalaya Hinoo, 1st Shift in the International Mathematics Olympiad (IMO) secured International Rank 1 and will be awarded Gold Medals, while Ameya Devarshi (Class 8) from Delhi Public School secured International Rank 3 in the International Social Studies Olympiad (ISSO) and will receive a Bronze Medal. Top performers from Jamshedpur Hitesh (Class 10) of Vivek Vidyalaya secured International Rank 2 in the International English Olympiad (IEO) and won a Silver Medal.

From Bokaro Shivaay Sinha (Class 03) from St. Xavier's School secured Rank 02 in the International Hindi Olympiad (IHO) and will be awarded a Silver Medal. Supriyo Dutta (Class 01) from Holy Cross School secured Rank 03 in the International Maths Olympiad (IMO) and will be awarded a Bronze Medal. Shristi Kumari (Class 04) from Mount Sion School secured Rank 03 in the International Social science Olympiad (ISSO).